CLASS 6 HANDOUT

Self Esteem (Value)

Finding Peace Within

What is it?

*Adapted from **Facing Codependence** by Pia Mellody, Andrea Miller, & J. Keith Miller*

- Healthy self-esteem is the internal experience of one's own preciousness and value as a person
  - Comes from inside
  - Moves outward into relationships
  - Doesn't change based on behavior or surroundings

What is the issue?

*Adapted from **Facing Codependence** by Pia Mellody, Andrea Miller, & J. Keith Miller*

- People with complex trauma have difficulty with self-esteem at one or both extremes
  - Low self-esteem
    - I think I am worth less than others
    - I dont measure up
  - Arrogant
    - I think I am superior to others
    - I have learned to find faults in others, making them inferior to me
- Both of these types of self-esteem result in what is called "Other-Esteem"
  - I get my value (sense of worth) from external things
    - It is based on my "human doing" or in the opinions and behavior of other people
    - Some examples
      - How I look
      - How much money I make
      - What I know
      - What kind of car I drive
      - What kind of job I have
      - How well my children behave
      - How attractive or powerful my spouse is
      - How well I perform

What does it look like?

*Adapted from **Facing Codependence** by Pia Mellody, Andrea Miller, & J. Keith Miller*

- Healthy Self-Esteem
  - Self-Esteem, Reality (Value)
    - I am enough
    - I Matter
    - I am perfectly imperfect
  - Boundaries, Reality, Moderation (Power)
    - I have enough control
    - I can influence my environment
    - I am in control of myself
  - Self-Care (Abundance)
    - I have enough
    - I can survive
    - I have joy in my life
- Unhealthy Self-Esteem
  - Self-Esteem, Reality (Worthless)
    - Prestige
    - Other-esteem
    - I am never enough
  - Boundaries, Reality, Moderation (Helpless)
    - Power over others
    - Negative control
    - I never have enough control
  - Self-Care (Hopeless)
    - Money and possessions
    - Hoarding
    - I never have enough

Understanding the Drama Triangle

*From **The Three Faces of Victim** by Lynne Forrest (edited by Imago Dei Ministries)*

- Three roles: Persecutor, Rescuer, and Victim (Stephen Karpman's "Drama Triangle")
  - Anytime we refuse to take responsibility for ourselves, we are opting to play victim
  - All three roles are faces of victim: they start from victim and end back at victim
  - A "shame machine": moving around the triangle keeps the shame messages going
- One-up, one-down
  - Rescuer and Persecutor sit at the top and come across as "better than"
  - The Victim is one-down; resentment builds until they retaliate (and become the persecutor)
  - Rescuer and Persecutor are the two opposite extremes of victim
- Starting gate position
  - We each have a most familiar role, learned in our family, that becomes part of our identity
  - We still rotate through all three roles, sometimes many times a day
  - Example: Mom threatens Junior (persecutor), Dad steps in to defend him (rescuer), Mom turns on Dad (now he is the victim), or Junior turns on Dad: "I don't need your help!"
- Inside our heads
  - We play all three roles in our own self-talk
  - "I'm so lazy" (persecutor → victim), then "I would have finished if it weren't for…" (rescuer)

The Three Roles

- Rescuer: the enabler, fixer, and mediator
  - A twisted version of the desire to nurture and protect
  - Comes from an unconscious need to feel important; taking care of others is how they connect and feel worth
  - Core belief: my needs don't count ("If I take care of others well enough, long enough, I'll get my turn")
  - Greatest fear: nobody will be there for them, so they make themselves indispensable
  - Fosters dependency, and needs someone to take care of
  - As victim: martyrdom and depression ("After all I've done for you…")
  - As persecutor: withdraws their care-taking
- Persecutor: the blamer
  - A twisted version of the desire to protect and provide; tries to "reform" others through force
  - Shame-based anger covers feelings of worthlessness; acting "better than" covers feeling "less than"
  - Must be right: preaching, blaming, lecturing, interrogating, attacking, getting even
  - Core belief: the world is dangerous ("Get them before they get me!")
  - Greatest fear: powerlessness; denies their weaknesses and needs someone to blame
  - As victim: justifies getting even ("If it weren't for you, I wouldn't have had to…")

- Victim: "I can't make it"
  - A twisted version of the innocent, vulnerable, needy child within us
  - Denies their problem-solving ability and their own power; sees themselves as the "unfixable problem"
  - Core belief and greatest fear: I can't make it on my own, so they look for someone more capable to carry them
  - Rescues from one-down ("You're the only one who can help me")
  - As persecutor: resents being dependent; sabotages help, plays "Yes, but…", uses guilt to hook a Rescuer

How we end up on the triangle

- Denied feelings: keeping others from feeling bad, or not allowing ourselves our own feelings
- Dishonesty: when we deny our feelings we can't know (or tell) our truth, so we keep hidden agendas
- Failed intimacy: believing we are unlovable makes keeping our distance feel necessary
- No one takes responsibility for themselves, and everyone ends up hurt and angry

How do I get off the drama triangle?

- Become aware of the triangle and of my starting gate position
- Take responsibility for myself (own my reality)
  - Allow myself to have my feelings
  - Allow others to have their feelings, without rescuing them
- Sit with guilt without acting on it; sometimes guilt only means I broke a dysfunctional family rule ("Don't talk about it", "It's selfish to take care of yourself")
- Get honest with myself and others; tell my truth and act on what it shows me
  - Rescuer: admit my investment in keeping others dependent, and start meeting my own needs
  - Persecutor: own my part and the ways I hurt others
  - Victim: start my own self-care and recognize my own problem-solving ability
- Be willing to let go of the drama produced
  - Set boundaries, even if it means walking away
- Expect to be seen as the "bad guy" (persecutor) by those still on the triangle; that doesn't make it so

Alternative to the Drama Triangle

*From **The Power of TED** by David Emerald*

The Empowerment Dynamic

- Generates confidence
  - through internal interaction or external communication keeps the confidence messages going
- Creator
  - A healthy version of the victim
  - focuses on what inspires them
  - outcome-focused and passion-powered
  - generates forward energy
- Challenger
  - A healthy version of the persecutor
  - consciously builds others up
  - focuses on using the circumstances for growth and learning
- Coach
  - A healthy version of the rescuer
  - sees the internal creator in others
  - above all remains supportive and encouraging

Exercise: Find your starting gate

Think of a recent conflict or tense moment, and map it onto the triangle.

1. What happened?

2. Who was the persecutor, the rescuer, and the victim?

3. Where did I step onto the triangle?

4. What would a Creator, Coach, or Challenger response have looked like?

How do I fix unhealthy self-esteem?

- Start with Reality
  - Learn what you are responsible for
    - Thoughts
    - Feelings
    - Choices
    - Limits
    - Behavior
- Contain your Reality with Boundaries
  - Where do my responsibilities end and someone else's start?
  - What limits do I want to place on my thoughts
- Understand your wants and needs with Self Care
  - Find out what my wants and needs are
  - Find out what wants and needs I want to share with others to allow them to meet those needs
- Set goals for moderation
  - Look at my Reality and value moderate responses
  - Give myself permission to miss the mark of moderation but ask myself "How do I want to do it different next time?"
- Look for feelings of self-worth and value generated by the previous steps
  - Validate what you have done and celebrate the little wins along with the big ones
  - Trust the process that as you work on yourself, you will being to see yourself as more and more valuable

Take-home: Where my value comes from

Each day this week, notice one moment you looked to others for your worth (other-esteem), and one moment you found it in yourself.

	I looked to others for my worth	I found it in myself
Day 1		
Day 2		
Day 3		
Day 4		
Day 5		
Day 6		
Day 7		

At the end of the week: what do I notice?

Group Questions

Check-in first Did you try the unsent letter? Share only what writing it was like, not what you wrote.

Answer from whichever level fits where you are tonight. It's fine to stay in Start.

Start

JUST STARTING OUT

1. What is one thing you like about yourself?

2. Which role on the drama triangle sounds most familiar to you: rescuer, persecutor, or victim?

Go deeper

APPLY TONIGHT'S IDEAS

3. What is one thing you value about yourself that doesn't depend on what you do or what others think?

4. On a hard day, does your sense of worth come from inside or from what others think? What helps you come back to your own value?

Stretch

FOR A BIGGER CHALLENGE

5. Which way onto the triangle do you recognize most in yourself: denied feelings, dishonesty, or failed intimacy?

6. Looking back over the six weeks, which piece most needs your attention to grow your self-esteem: reality, boundaries, self care, or moderation? What's one next step?